

The New London: Good Growth [B2]

Dopo essere stato eletto per il terzo mandato come sindaco, Sadiq Khan si è impegnato a completare il London Plan, un ambizioso progetto economico, sociale, ambientale e dei trasporti per lo sviluppo della città nei prossimi vent'anni.



London, [along with](#) Istanbul, Moscow and Paris, is among the largest cities on the European continent. The metropolitan county of Greater London covers a geographic area of 1,572 square kilometres (607 square miles). As part of the job, the Mayor of London has to produce a spatial development strategy — or London Plan — for this entire area. The current London Plan, substantially revised by current mayor Sadiq Khan in 2021, reflects an urgent situation in Britain’s capital, one shared by other major cities worldwide. It rests on a [commitment](#) of “good growth”; genuinely sustainable, inclusive growth that benefits all Londoners.

RICH CITY/POOR CITY

Strategic planning is the shared responsibility of the Mayor of London, thirty-two London boroughs and the Corporation of the City of London. To simplify, the Greater London Authority was established in 1999, consisting of the Mayor and a twenty-five-member London Assembly who scrutinise his or her work. All these people are [voted in](#) by Londoners every four years, and may belong to different political parties. London has a population of around 8.9 million. By 2035, an estimated 9.6 million people will be living in the city. But the demographic has changed since the 20th century. Now, the capital is home to some of the wealthiest and the poorest people in the UK. It has more than thirty-four thousand empty properties owned by rich people who do not live there most of the time. Poor people come in from the [outskirts](#) of London to work. [Rough sleeping](#) has increased by over 50 per cent in the last decade. There has been a significant decline in people in their 20s and 30s living in London, and there are many fewer children. This is because the jobs the city needs to stay lively, vibrant and diverse don’t pay enough to live here.

AFFORDABLE HOUSING

The mayor believes that more [affordable](#) housing is the answer. The London Plan has set a target of 52,300 homes each year for the next five years and 50 per cent of all new housing will be “genuinely [affordable](#).” Forty thousand new [council homes](#) have been promised by 2030. Key locations in London are specified in the London Plan as “opportunity areas” with the best potential for new homes, jobs and infrastructure of all types. A good example is the Royal [Docks](#) and Beckton Riverside, across the River Thames from Greenwich. Thamesmead and Abbey Wood in southeast London also has potential for eight thousand new homes and four thousand new jobs by 2041. Barking Riverside in East London is another key area, with 10,800 homes planned — though this is dependent on improved [transport links](#) to central London. Completed in 2022, the Elizabeth line rail service crosses London east to west as far as Heathrow Airport and beyond. As a result, more opportunities exist in this area, known as the Great West Corridor.

ECO-DESIGN

Of course, building can't be [rampant](#), and there are already [complaints](#) from towns on the [outskirts](#) of London who believe that their identity may be lost. The London Plan tries to mitigate this by placing emphasis on high environmental, health and safety standards for building design, and on the principle of [fostering](#) healthy communities. After the Grenfell Tower fire killed seventy-two people in 2017, fire safety is considered [throughout](#) the construction process. Seasonal [flooding](#) from the Thames is also a concern. Eco-friendly features that may help include the installation of sustainable [drainage](#) systems such as green roofs on buildings. There are also more [facilities](#) for [waste disposal](#) and recycling.

ZERO CARBON BY 2030

In 2019, London became the world's first National Park City. The grassroots movement is supported in the London Plan, with an ambitious target of London achieving [net zero](#) by 2030. The National Park City programme promises a London with more than 50 per cent green space by 2050. The city has adopted the Urban Greening Factor model, an international planning policy tool designed to encourage more and better urban greening. Local projects include the Greener City Fund, with over half a million trees planted to date, and rewilding in London.

PUBLIC TRANSPORT

A huge part of the [net zero](#) plan is to reduce Londoners' dependency on cars and encourage walking, cycling and public transport instead, with a target set at 80 per cent share by 2041. A series of incentives continues to encourage use of public transport. They include the [Hopper](#) bus [fare](#) (unlimited journeys on Transport for London (TfL) bus and tram services for £1.75 for one hour), a [freeze](#) on TfL [fares](#) until March 2025, the Night Tube (a 24-hour service that now runs on some lines on Fridays and Saturdays), and continued investment in greener buses, electric taxis and many more protected London cycling lanes.

THE ULEZ

The London Plan has been [praised](#) for its attention to data. The requirement to report on energy performance has led to immediate carbon reductions. Air pollution is monitored with real-time alerts on London's transport network, and air filters have been put in schools in London's most polluted areas. More polluting vehicles have been taken off London's roads through the T-Charge (a daily 'toxicity' charge of £10, mainly applying to diesel and petrol vehicles registered before 2006); and the Ultra-Low Emission Zone (ULEZ) for London has been expanded. While the ULEZ, under which [motorists](#) must pay £12.50 a day to

drive a [non-compliant](#) car, has been controversial (impacting poorer people with older cars, and [tripping up](#) tourists), it has worked.

A GREAT SOCIAL LEVELLER

Emphasis has been placed on projects of economic and social value that promote a circular economy. The London Plan promotes investment in green jobs, supporting efforts to turn the capital into a global centre for green finance; that is, investment in socially-responsible [endeavours](#). The Solar Action Plan promotes local clean energies and energy efficiency. London's entrepreneurs are encouraged with climate-focused programmes such as Better Futures. The London Plan is ambitious and ahead of the UK's legal requirements. Its integrated approach [aimsto boost](#) the physical and mental well-being of Londoners by providing better and more [affordable](#) housing and encouraging cleaner ways to travel and to work. It makes city parks, arts and culture more accessible, assuring their survival. "It is people on foot who make urban centres vibrant and they support economic activity," says the mayor, "Air quality improves and congestion reduces. [It] makes them safer for others, and it is a great social [leveller](#)."

Glossary

- **voted in** = votare
- **council homes** = case popolari
- **fare** = tariffa
- **outskirts** = periferia, sobborghi
- **Docks** = moli
- **throughout** = durante, per tutto
- **drainage** = drenaggio
- **waste disposal** = smaltimento dei rifiuti
- **aims** = mirare
- **leveller.** = livellatore
- **Hopper** = saltare
- **commitment** = impegno
- **transport links** = collegamenti di trasporto
- **to boost** = aumentare
- **praised** = lodare, elogiare
- **motorists** = guidatore
- **along with** = insieme a
- **rampant** = incontrollato
- **complaints** = lamentele
- **flooding** = inondazioni
- **facilities** = strutture
- **tripping up** = confondere
- **endeavours** = sforzi
- **fostering** = promuovere
- **Rough sleeping** = dormire in strada
- **affordable** = accessibile
- **net zero** = zero emissioni
- **freeze** = congelamento
- **non-compliant** = non conforme